

D644

Foundations of Strategic Communications

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A plant manager at a paper mill founded in 1911 emails a new safety rule to 300 workers. Most work on the loud factory floor and rarely check email, and few follow the new rule. The email used the company's new font. In a sender-channel-receiver model, what failed?

- A. The receivers, for ignoring the rule.
- B. The font made the email unreadable.
- C. The channel: email didn't reach floor workers, so the message was never received.
- D. The sender's encoding of the rule.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A city transit agency with 1,200 employees must announce a fare increase. Its riders include many older adults and students without cars. The agency director studied journalism. What is the best first planning step?

- A. Let the director write it because of his degree.
- B. Post only on social media because it is fastest.
- C. Analyze each audience's needs, concerns, and preferred channels before drafting.
- D. Draft one press release for everyone.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

At a fundraiser for a food bank with a 25-year history, the speaker says, "Every \$50 gift provides 200 meals; last year gifts fed 12,000 families." The event was held in a renovated barn. Which appeal is she mainly using?

- A. Ethos
- B. Logos
- C. Ethos, because the barn setting builds trust.
- D. Pathos

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A speaker wants to strengthen ethos in a talk on workplace safety. What should she add?

- A.** Her 15 years as a certified safety inspector.
- B.** A chart of injury rates.
- C.** A moving story about an injured worker's family.
- D.** Nothing; ethos only comes from what the audience already believes.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A software company is emailing IT directors at mid-size firms who are carefully comparing security products before a purchase. The company's mascot is a fox. Which approach fits the elaboration likelihood model?

- A.** Feature the fox mascot prominently.
- B.** Central route: detailed evidence such as test results and certifications.
- C.** Always use both routes equally for every audience.
- D.** Peripheral route: a celebrity endorsement.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An audience scrolls quickly through social media with little interest in the topic. Which ELM approach fits?

- A.** No approach; low-interest audiences can't be persuaded.
- B.** Central route: a 12-page white paper.
- C.** Central route, because facts persuade everyone most.
- D.** Peripheral route: an eye-catching visual, a familiar spokesperson, and a short message.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

Two press releases describe the same new surgery program at a teaching hospital known for its rooftop garden. One says "90% survival rate"; the other says "10% mortality rate." Readers rate the first more favorably. What explains the difference?

- A.** The releases report different facts.
- B.** The rooftop garden photo in one release.
- C.** Framing
- D.** Agenda setting

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A company's communications manager, who also runs a popular personal hiking blog, posts a written claim that a named local supplier knowingly sold contaminated food. The claim is false. The supplier is a private business. What legal risk does this create?

- A. None, because personal blogs are protected opinion.
- B. Copyright infringement
- C. Slander
- D. Libel

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A company accused of defamation over a published statement can prove the statement was true. What is the effect?

- A. Truth matters only when the target is a public figure.
- B. Truth is a defense; a true statement is not defamatory.
- C. Truth is a defense only if the statement was spoken.
- D. It is still liable because the statement hurt reputation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A beauty brand with stores in 12 malls pays an influencer who has 400,000 followers to post reviews of its new serum. What is required?

- A. Disclosure only for accounts over 500,000 followers.
- B. A note on the profile page is enough.
- C. No disclosure if the review is honest.
- D. The post itself must clearly disclose the paid relationship.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A campaign for a regional blood bank that just remodeled its donor lounge set this objective: "Send 40 press releases this year." Which revision is a proper outcome objective?

- A. Increase first-time donors 15%, from 2,000 to 2,300, by December 31.
- B. Earn 40 media placements this year.
- C. Showcase the new donor lounge.
- D. Make the community love the blood bank.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An objective calls for increasing event registrations 25% over last year's 480. What is the target number?

- A.** 600
- B.** 120
- C.** 505
- D.** 384

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	—	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A plant manager at a paper mill ~~founded in 1911~~ emails a new safety rule to 300 workers. Most work on the loud factory floor and rarely check email, and few follow the new rule. ~~The email used the company's new font.~~ In a sender-channel-receiver model, what failed?

Target word: failed model element **Decides:** Receivers don't use the channel chosen.

A	Inverted operation	They never got the message.
B	Camouflage	The font isn't why workers missed it.
C	Correct	A channel the audience doesn't use blocks the message.
D	Adjacent category	Nothing suggests the wording was unclear.

2. Answer C Concept 2

A city transit agency ~~with 1,200 employees~~ must announce a fare increase. Its riders include many older adults and students without cars. ~~The agency director studied journalism.~~ What is the best first planning step?

Target word: first step **Decides:** Distinct audiences with different needs and channels.

A	Camouflage	Who writes it doesn't replace audience analysis.
B	Absolute language	Many older riders may not see it.
C	Correct	Strategy starts with the audience.
D	Dropped element	Skips audience analysis.

3. Answer B Concept 3

At a fundraiser for a food bank ~~with a 25-year history~~, the speaker says, "Every \$50 gift provides 200 meals; last year gifts fed 12,000 families." ~~The event was held in a renovated barn.~~ Which appeal is she mainly using?

Target word: name the appeal **Decides:** Numbers and cause-and-effect.

A	Adjacent category	She isn't citing her credibility.
B	Correct	Evidence and logic.
C	Camouflage	The venue isn't the appeal in the message.
D	Confusion set	No emotional story; these are figures.

4. Answer A Concept 3 · transfer

A speaker wants to strengthen ethos in a talk on workplace safety. What should she add?

Target word: build ethos **Decides:** Ethos = credibility.

A	Correct	Credentials build credibility.
B	Adjacent category	That is logos.
C	Confusion set	That is pathos.
D	Absolute language	Speakers can build credibility in the message.

5. Answer B Concept 4

A software company is emailing IT directors at mid-size firms who are carefully comparing security products before a purchase. ~~The company's mascot is a fox.~~ Which approach fits the elaboration likelihood model?

Target word: route to use **Decides:** High motivation and ability.

A	Camouflage	A mascot is a peripheral cue, a poor fit here.
B	Correct	Engaged, careful readers are persuaded by strong arguments.
C	Absolute language	ELM says match the route to involvement.
D	Inverted operation	Cues work on low-involvement audiences.

6. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

An audience scrolls quickly through social media with little interest in the topic. Which ELM approach fits?

Target word: route for low involvement **Decides:** Low motivation to process.

A	Absolute language	They can be, through cues.
B	Inverted operation	They won't process detailed arguments.
C	Confusion set	Ignores the audience's involvement.
D	Correct	Cues persuade low-involvement audiences.

7. Answer C Concept 5

Two press releases describe the same new surgery program at a teaching hospital ~~known for its rooftop garden.~~ One says "90% survival rate"; the other says "10% mortality rate." Readers rate the first more favorably. What explains the difference?

Target word: name the effect **Decides:** Same facts, different wording.

A	Inverted operation	90% survival and 10% mortality are the same fact.
B	Camouflage	Nothing says the releases differed in images.
C	Correct	A gain frame reads better than an equal loss frame.
D	Confusion set	That is about what topics people think about, not how.

8. Answer D Concept 6

A company's communications manager, ~~who also runs a popular personal hiking blog,~~ posts a written claim that a named local supplier knowingly sold contaminated food. The claim is false. The supplier is a private business. What legal risk does this create?

Target word: name the risk **Decides:** False, published, harms reputation.

A	Camouflage	A false factual claim isn't opinion, wherever it's posted.
B	Adjacent category	No one's work was copied.
C	Confusion set	Slander is spoken.
D	Correct	A false written statement of fact that harms reputation.

9. Answer B Concept 6 • transfer

A company accused of defamation over a published statement can prove the statement was true. What is the effect?

Target word: effect of truth **Decides:** Falsity is required for defamation.

A	Adjacent category	Truth is a defense for private targets too.
B	Correct	Defamation requires a false statement.
C	Confusion set	Truth defends both libel and slander.
D	Inverted operation	Harm alone isn't enough; it must be false.

10. Answer D Concept 7

A beauty brand ~~with stores in 12 malls~~ pays an influencer who has 400,000 followers to post reviews of its new serum. What is required?

Target word: disclosure duty **Decides:** A paid relationship exists.

A	Camouflage	Follower count doesn't change the duty.
B	Adjacent category	Disclosure must be in the endorsement, where viewers see it.
C	Dropped element	Honesty doesn't replace disclosure.
D	Correct	Material connections must be clear and conspicuous.

11. Answer A Concept 8

A campaign for a regional blood bank ~~that just remodeled its donor lounge~~ set this objective: "Send 40 press releases this year." Which revision is a proper outcome objective?

Target word: outcome objective **Decides:** Measurable behavior change with baseline and deadline.

A	Correct	$2,000 \times 1.15 = 2,300$; a measurable behavior change with a deadline.
B	Adjacent category	Placements are outputs, not audience outcomes.
C	Camouflage	An activity, not an outcome.
D	Dropped element	Not measurable or time-bound.

12. Answer A Concept 8 • transfer

An objective calls for increasing event registrations 25% over last year's 480. What is the target number?

Target word: solve for target **Decides:** 480×1.25 .

A	Correct	$480 \times 1.25 = 600$.
B	Dropped element	That is only the increase.
C	Confusion set	Adds 25 registrations instead of 25%.
D	Inverted operation	Reduces by 20% instead of increasing by 25%.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	8	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Communication models	Sender encodes a message, sends it through a channel, and the receiver decodes it; noise or a poor channel choice blocks meaning.	Blaming receivers when the channel never reached them.	A message was sent but not received or acted on.
2	Audience analysis first	Strategic messages start with who the audience is, what they need, and which channels they use.	Drafting one message for everyone.	Several distinct audiences for one announcement.
3	Rhetorical appeals	Ethos = credibility; pathos = emotion; logos = logic and evidence.	Calling statistics pathos or credentials logos.	Numbers, stories, or credentials in a message.
4	Elaboration likelihood model	Motivated, able audiences take the central route (strong arguments); low-involvement audiences take the peripheral route (cues).	Assuming facts always persuade best.	How carefully the audience is thinking.
5	Framing	How the same facts are presented (gain vs. loss, emphasis) changes how people judge them.	Confusing framing with agenda setting.	Same facts, different wording, different reactions.
6	Defamation	Defamation is a false statement of fact that harms reputation; libel is written/published, slander is spoken; truth is a defense.	Mixing libel and slander, or thinking true statements can be defamatory.	A false claim about a named party.
7	Disclosure of paid endorsements	Paid or material relationships must be clearly and conspicuously disclosed in the endorsement itself.	Thinking honesty or follower count removes the duty.	An influencer or reviewer is compensated.
8	Outcome objectives	Objectives should target measurable changes in audience awareness, attitude, or behavior, with a baseline and deadline — not outputs.	Counting releases or placements as objectives.	An objective based on activity.

Course scope (public description): Foundations of Strategic Communications provides a foundation for developing clear, concise, and compelling messaging for specific situations and audiences across various business purposes. Students will be introduced to strategic communication theories and the legal and ethical issues to consider when planning, implementing, and evaluating communications based on intended goals, outcomes, and audiences. In this course, students will collaborate with peers as they gain the skills necessary to be effective and ethical communicators. Students will develop confidence in presenting ideas, persuading others, and navigating complex strategic communications situations.